



Buy Online PickUp In Store (BOPIS) Experience : Project Report

HCDE 517 | Winter 2026

The Home Depot

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THE
HOME
DEPOT



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1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Our client was The Home Depot, one of the world's largest home improvement retailers, with stores across North America. Our research focused on investigating the Buy Online, Pick Up in Store (BOPIS) process. This omnichannel shopping experience was introduced to improve customers' hybrid shopping experience. This allows shoppers to order items online (website or app) and select for the items to be picked up either through desk pickup or locker pickup in store.

The purpose of this study was to evaluate the usability and customer experience of Home Depot's digital app ordering process, as well as the physical nuances of the in-store pickup interactions. Our goal was to identify and understand pain points of the Do-It-Yourself (DIY) customer user groups throughout their end-to-end shopping journey, from ordering selected products online via the Home Depot app to picking the items up in store through Home Depot's in-store pickup options. The long-term goal of this study is to provide insights into improving customer satisfaction and trust in the omnichannel shopping experience by reducing customer complaints and pickup errors while aligning research findings with current business goals.

Our target audience was DIY homeowners and renters. The ideal user would be customers who own their home or rent an apartment and prefer to tackle home repairs, improvements, and projects themselves rather than hiring contractors. Our decision to focus on DIY user groups was guided by our client sponsor, as research showed that these customers used the in-store pickup and locker pickup the most. We split the usability testing into two main phases to explore the Buy Online, Pick Up in Store (BOPIS) customer experiences. The buy online portion focused on app usability testing, while the pickup in store focused on in-person pickup usability testing. 

2. OVERVIEW OF RESEARCH QUESTIONS

In order to achieve the research objective, usability tests were conducted aimed at answering three overarching research questions. The questions and a summarization of their findings are below:



Research Questions	Summary Insights 
How effectively can DIY customers navigate the online ordering process for in-store pickup? What factors influence their understanding of pickup options and eligibility?	DIY customers were generally able to navigate the online ordering process for in-store pickup through the app. Some participants experienced confusion during the product search and discovery stage, particularly when trying to locate the exact product they intended to purchase. While adding their items to cart and confirming their order details in the checkout stage, most were able to select the in-store pickup option, but several needed additional clarity around the wording used to describe this option.
How do DIY customers' expectations about the pickup timeline and process align with what Home Depot communicates and the actual in-store experience?	DIY customers' expectations about the pickup timeline and process were not always aligned with what was communicated through the app and follow-up notifications. Several participants found the pickup timeline to be unclear or insufficiently explained, which created uncertainty about when their order would be ready. Participants also reported that the email notifications contained an excessive amount of information, making it difficult to quickly identify the key details needed for pickup. In addition, the notifications did not always clearly communicate where in the store items should be picked up, leading to confusion about the in-store pickup process once customers arrived.
What factors enable or impede effective communication and interaction during the in-store pickup experience?	Participants relied on multiple communication touchpoints throughout the in-store pickup journey, including app and email notifications, estimated pickup timelines, and in-store signage.



	When these channels convey clear, consistent information, they help set expectations and enable participants to navigate the pickup process with confidence. Participants reported that once items were bought online, the email notifications often contained excessive amounts of information, making it difficult to quickly identify essential details such as order status or pickup instructions. Unclear or inconsistent messaging around pickup timelines also created uncertainty about when customers should arrive at the store, and the lack of clarity on the number of items that are ready for pickup impeded interactions while in store. Additionally, limited or unclear in-store signage required participants to seek assistance from staff to locate the correct pickup area; participants noted that they were not always able to recognize that they should go straight to the lockers upon arrival and needed assistance from the customer help desks.
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3. OVERVIEW OF USABILITY FINDINGS

Findings	Severity	Impact	Recommendations
1.1: Search and product discoverability are difficult without precise specifications	High	Users struggle to locate correct items, increasing search time and item abandonment	Provide guided search support by providing aligned 'similar item' listings, measurement standardization, and contextual project guidance based on search.
1.2: Product results & listings are inconsistent with user expectations	High	Users feel lost navigating results and must repeatedly adjust searches	Standardize listing layout and provide clearer product grouping.



1.3: Fulfillment terms are confusing	High	Users accidentally tend to select incorrect fulfillment options	Visually separate pick up vs. ship to store with clearer explanation of the difference.
1.4: Checkout introduces friction	Medium-High	Adds friction due to required account creation and created confusion after use of alternative check out methods	Introduce a guest checkout option and include a way to track order based on confirmation code rather than creating an account.
1.5: Pickup communication and instructions are unclear	High	Participants were unsure where to pick up their order or had difficulty locating instructions for in-store pickup	Provide concise pickup instructions at the top of emails and notifications, highlighting key steps such as pickup location, authentication requirements, and order readiness status.

4. PARTICIPANT PROFILES

We recruited participants across three testing areas: the Home Depot app experience, the locker pickup, and the customer service desk. As previously stated, for both app and in-store testing, our target user was the DIY homeowner or renter.

Our initial scope focused solely on experienced Home Depot customers and excluded first-time customers, but we adjusted for two reasons: we decided to include our two pilot testers, who were both first-time users, and convenience sampling during in-store recruitment made it difficult to screen for experience level.

Throughout this report, app testing participants are referenced as A.P1-A.P7, in-store locker participants are referenced as L.P1-L.P5, and customer service desk participants are referenced as D.P1-D.P5.



Participant Citation Index

Test area	Test Area shorthand	Participant 1 shorthand	Code becomes
App Testing	A	P1	A.P1
In-Store Locker	L	P1	L.P1
In-Store Customer Service Desk	D	P1	D.P1

Our findings show that participant shopping habits fell into at least one of two categories: those who are DIY homeowners or renters who complete home projects, and everyday need fulfillers such as artists, plant enthusiasts, or those making small item pickups. This is important because it justifies our decision to exclude contractors our goal was to focus on everyday home improvement customers rather than customers who used Home Depot for professional purposes.

DIY homeowners or renters:

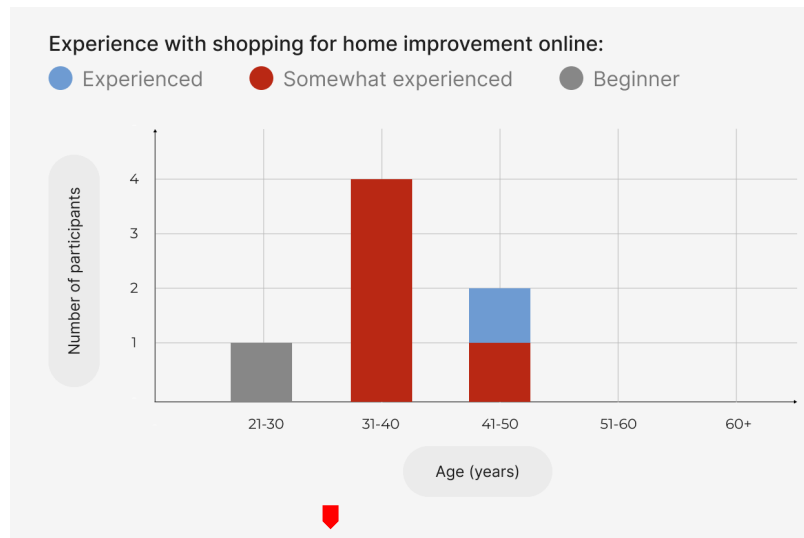
“Home Depot I’ve used, great place to go to find anything I need for home appliances. And as far as big projects we use vendors, but smaller stuff, we’re happy to do ourselves.” [A.P5]

Everyday need fulfillers:

“[Going to Home Depot is] definitely just a once in a while, small project thing. Most of the time in the gardening section.” [A.P4]

4.1 App Testing

A total of 7 participants were tested for the app experience portion of the study. Of the 7 participants, there were 4 male and 3 female participants. This group included 2 novice users who had no experience with the Home Depot app and 5 returning users who had prior experience placing and picking up online orders.



4.2 In-Store Testing: Locker Pickup & Customer Service Desk

A total of 5 participants were tested for each in-store pickup method, the customer service desk and the locker. Similar to app testing, this group included 2 novice users and 8 returning users across both locker and desk pickup.

5. METHODS AND PROCEDURES



5.1 App Testing

To evaluate the digital portion of Home Depot's Buy Online, Pick Up in Store (BOPIS) experience, the research team conducted remote usability testing of the Home Depot mobile app. The goal of this phase was to understand how customers navigate the ordering process, interpret pickup options, and manage communication related to in-store pickup through the app.

The team used a mixed-methods approach combining remote think-aloud usability testing and structured interviews. This approach allowed researchers to observe how participants interacted with the app in real time while also capturing participants' reasoning, expectations, and decision-making processes.

To balance depth of insight with recruitment feasibility, participants completed tasks across multiple touchpoints of the BOPIS journey. Depending on participant availability and



willingness to commit to the full process, participants interacted with different stages of the ordering flow. Each session lasted approximately 35-45 minutes, and participants were asked to verbalize their thoughts using the think-aloud method while completing tasks within the Home Depot app.

Recruiting Participants

Participants for the app testing portion of the study were recruited through a combination of peer outreach and support from our client sponsor. Members of the research team reached out to peers within their networks; the client sponsor supported by identifying individuals who had previously and/or frequently shopped at Home Depot, and the team reached out to those individuals.

All potential participants completed a brief screening questionnaire to ensure they aligned with target user profiles for the study. Screening criteria ensured that participants had familiarity with Home Depot or similar home improvement retailers and were comfortable completing tasks using a mobile shopping app.

Participants were required to meet the following general criteria:

- Have prior experience shopping at Home Depot in-store or online
- Be familiar with using mobile apps for retail purchases
- Be a homeowner or renter

Final Participants

Participants in the app testing portion of the study consisted of people who had prior experience shopping at Home Depot in-store, using the Home Depot mobile app, or purchasing items for home improvement and DIY projects. Given that this study focused on the Buy Online, Pick Up in Store workflow, participants represented customers who were likely to use digital ordering before retrieving items at a physical store location.

Participants varied in their level of familiarity with Home Depot's app experience. Some participants had previously used the Home Depot app or online ordering system, while others were more familiar with in-store shopping and were navigating the mobile ordering experience for the first time. Due to the constrained timeline, we also captured participants who were first-time users of the Home Depot app. These users would not have initially met our criteria nor our intention as outlined in our intended participant profiles; however, we decided to keep



their data in our study, as we noticed a nuanced perspective that they provided into the experiences of a novice/new Home Depot app user. We believed that their perspectives provided us with valuable insights that could be used in future studies.

The mix of familiarity allowed the research team to observe both experienced behaviors and first-time interactions, providing insight into how different types of users interpret pickup options, product availability, and communication during the ordering process.

Equipment and Environment

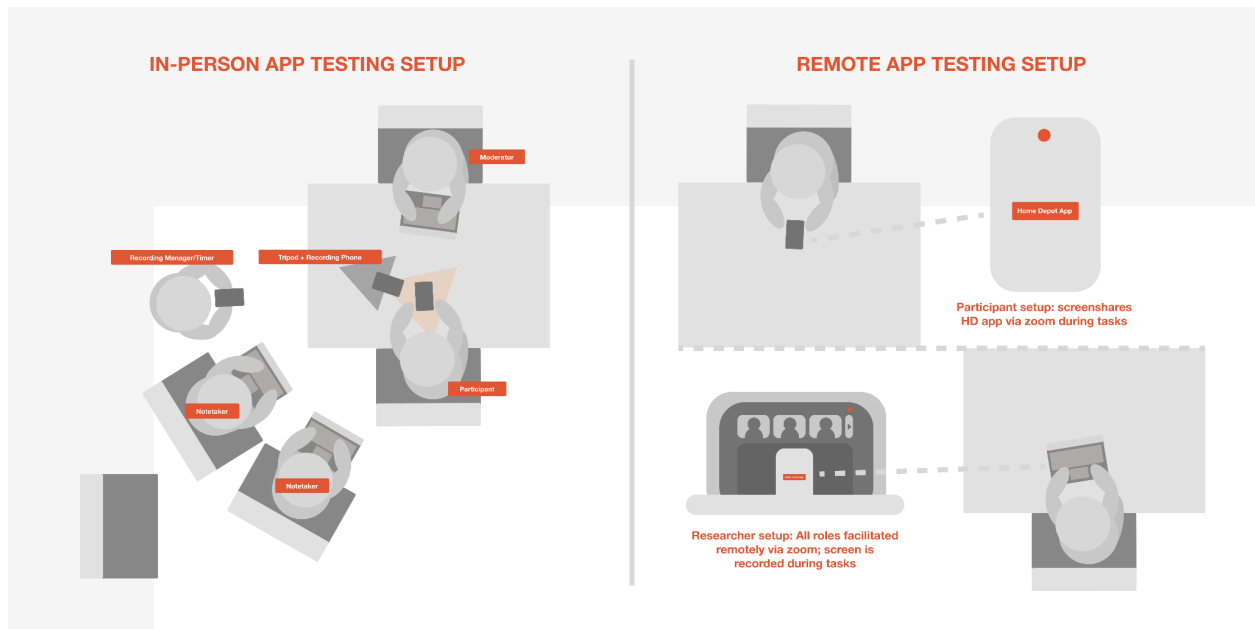
The research team consisted of four researchers who participated in conducting and documenting the usability sessions. The majority of our sessions were conducted remotely due to participant availability and convenience; in order to remain consistent, we had participants complete the tasks using their own mobile devices.

During each session:

- One researcher served as the session moderator, guiding the participant through the study protocol and prompting the think-aloud process.
- One researcher focused on documenting general observations, usability challenges, notable moments of confusion and success, and participant quotes.
- One researcher focused on documenting interactions users had with the app as it pertained to each task
- One researcher focused on timekeeping, recording sessions, and ensuring that technology worked smoothly throughout the session.

Roles rotated across sessions to ensure that each member of the research team contributed to moderation, observation, and documentation.

To maintain consistency across sessions, the team used a shared testing script, protocol, and note-taking template to capture participant behaviors, decision points, and usability challenges throughout the ordering process.



Testing Procedures

Each testing session followed a consistent structure to ensure comparable data across participants.

Pre-test arrangements (5 minutes)

Researchers reviewed the study purpose with participants and confirmed consent for participation and session recording. Participants were also asked to confirm that they completed the consent form and verbally consented to being recorded.

Session Introduction (2 minutes)

The moderator explained the goals of the session, the overall format of the usability test, and the think-aloud protocol. Participants were encouraged to verbalize their thoughts, expectations, and questions while interacting with the application.

Background interview (5-10 minutes)

Before beginning the tasks, participants answered questions related to their experience with home improvement projects and their familiarity with Home Depot's services. Discussion topics included:



- Experience with DIY or home improvement tasks
- Frequency of shopping at Home Depot
- Preferences for online versus in-store shopping
- Prior experience with Buy Online, Pick Up In Store
- Current or upcoming home project needs

This portion of the interview helped contextualize participant behaviours during the testing tasks.

Tasks (15-25 minutes)

Participants then completed a series of tasks using the Home Depot mobile app while thinking aloud. These tasks simulated a typical BOPIS ordering flow and were designed to reveal how participants navigated the application, interpreted pickup options, and verified order details.

Participants completed the following tasks:

Tasks	What was observed?
1. Selecting their preferred store to shop from.	Participants opened the Home Depot app and determined the store location they would prefer to shop from and retrieve their order.
2. Search and select the item they wish to purchase	Participants used the search function to locate an item they would want to purchase for a home improvement or DIY project.
3. Verify product's availability for in-store pickup, and confirm store for pickup	Participants reviewed product availability and confirmed whether the item was eligible for in-store pickup. Participants also selected or confirmed the store location for pickup.
4. Place an order for in-store pickup	Participants added the item to their cart and proceeded through the checkout process. Participants entered payment information or used digital payment methods such as Apple Pay.
5. Confirm the order has been	Participants reviewed the order confirmation screen to ensure



placed and that all details are accurate.

that the pickup location, product information, and order details were correct. Participants also reviewed the email (if applicable) to ensure the information sent to them matched the information on the app.

Post-test debriefing (10-15 minutes)

Following the task completion, researchers conducted a short debrief interview to capture participants' overall impressions of the experience. Participants were asked to reflect on

- Their overall experience navigating the Home Depot app
- Points of ease, confusion, difficulty during the process
- Their confidence after placing the order and having the information needed to pick up in store
- Their expectations for the in-store pickup experience
- How their experience with Home Depot app compares to other online app experiences

Participants also discussed their reactions to order confirmation communications, including email notifications and pickup instructions.

5.2 In-store Testing

We conducted fly-on-the-wall observations while in-store to trace customers' store navigation patterns and interactions with locker and help desk interfaces/services while picking up their order.

Immediately after customers complete their pickup, we conduct customer intercepts and do a brief interview. These conversations will focus on their post-order and in-store experience to provide additional perspectives on communication effectiveness and pickup execution.

Recruiting Participants

Participants for the in-store pickup portion of the study were recruited using a customer interception approach at the Home Depot Shoreline store (1335 N 205th St, Shoreline, WA). Researchers positioned themselves near the pickup locker area and the customer service



pickup desk, where customers completing an in-store pickup interaction naturally pass through during the fulfillment process.

After customers completed their pickup, members of the research team briefly approached them and invited them to participate in the study. This approach allowed the team to recruit participants who had just experienced the pickup process, ensuring that their feedback and behaviors reflected the real-world pickup experience.

To maintain consistency in the study, researchers confirmed that participants met the basic criteria for inclusion before conducting the interview. Participants needed to:

- Be customers who had placed an online order and were completing an in-store pickup
- Have familiarity with Home Depot's shopping experience
- Be willing to briefly discuss their pickup experience after completing their order

This recruitment strategy enabled the research team to observe authentic pickup behaviors in a natural retail environment while capturing immediate reflections from customers about the clarity, efficiency, and usability of the pickup process.

Final Participants

Participants in the in-store testing portion of the study were customers completing a Buy Online, Pick Up In Store (BOPIS) order at the Home Depot Shoreline store. The study focused on Do-It-Yourself (DIY) homeowners and renters, a key customer segment that frequently shops at Home Depot and often completes home improvement tasks independently. These users typically purchase tools, supplies, and project materials online and retrieve them through the in-store pickup service.

Participants represented a mix of customers with varying levels of familiarity with Home Depot's pickup process. Some participants reported regularly using the BOPIS service for small items retrieved from pickup lockers, while others used the help-desk pickup area for larger or less frequently purchased items.

Because participants were recruited through customer interception at the store, the final participant group consisted of individuals who had just completed an in-store pickup interaction, ensuring that observations and feedback reflected their immediate experience navigating the pickup process. This approach enabled the research team to capture authentic



user behaviors, navigation patterns, and reactions while interacting with locker systems, store signage, and the customer service desk during pickup.

Participants also varied in their shopping habits and project needs, including individuals purchasing items for DIY home projects, apartment repairs, and everyday household needs. This diversity helped provide a broader understanding of how different types of Home Depot customers experience the in-store pickup workflow.

Equipment and Environment

The research team consisted of four researchers, divided across the two primary pickup contexts. Two researchers were positioned near the locker pickup area, while two researchers were stationed near the customer service pickup desk. The research team consisted of four researchers, distributed across the two pickup contexts:

- Two researchers stationed near the locker pickup area
- Two researchers stationed near the customer service desk pickup area

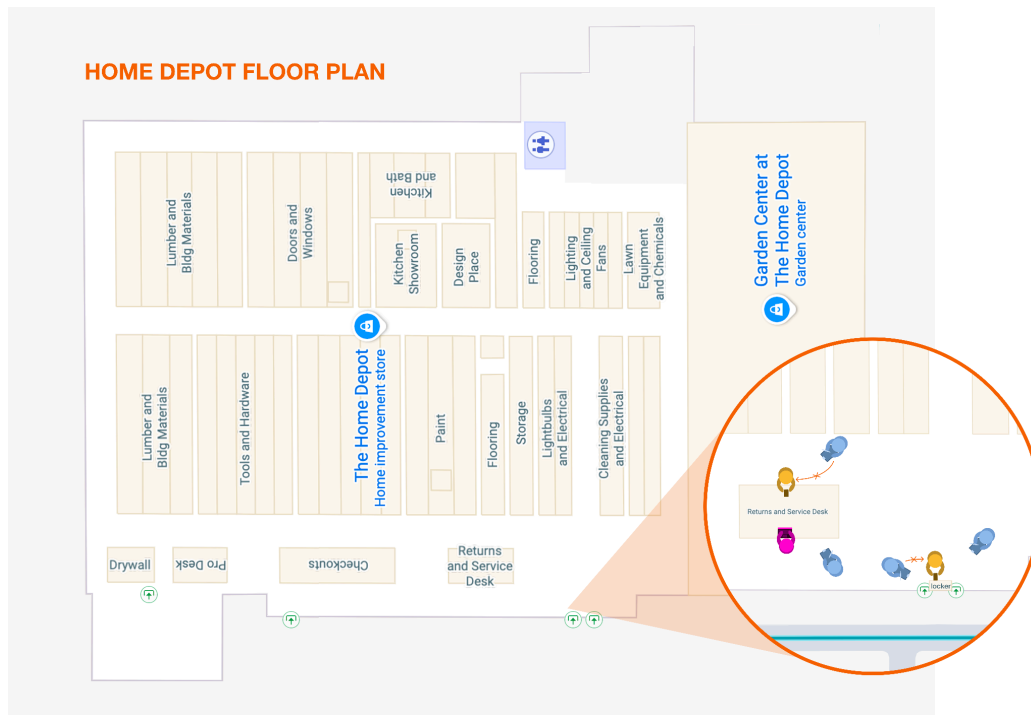
At each location:

- One researcher observed participant behavior and conducted the follow-up interview
- One researcher documented observations through written notes and photographs of relevant touchpoints such as signage and locker interfaces (with participant consent)

Roles rotated across sessions so each researcher participated in observation, questioning, and documentation.

To maintain consistency across sessions, the research team used a shared testing template and note-taking worksheet to document participant behaviors, interactions, and quotes during each observation. Researchers recorded key moments such as navigation decisions, hesitation points, and workarounds as participants progressed through the pickup process. Basic equipment included mobile phones for note-taking and timing, as well as devices used to capture photographs of the testing environment when appropriate.

Roles among the research team rotated across sessions to ensure that all members contributed to observation, documentation, and participant interaction during the study.



Testing Procedures

Each in-store session lasted approximately 15–20 minutes and followed a consistent structure. Participants were briefly introduced to the study and informed that the goal was to understand the pickup experience rather than evaluate their personal performance. Researchers confirmed that participants met the screening criteria and obtained verbal consent to observe their pickup interaction.

Fly-on-the-wall procedures

Participants were then observed completing their pickup as they normally would in the store environment. The moderator remained unobtrusive and did not provide assistance.

Participants completed the following tasks:

Tasks	What was observed?
1. Pickup instruction comprehension & understanding of where to go.	Participants determined whether their order should be picked up from a locker or the help-desk pickup area using available cues such as email notifications or signage.



2. Locate the right pickup area once you reach the store.	Participants navigated the store to locate the appropriate pickup location using environmental cues, signage, or digital displays.
3. Authenticate Your Pickup.	Participants verified their order using one of the standard authentication methods, including scanning a QR code, entering a pickup code, or presenting an email confirmation and photo ID.
4. Complete the pickup	Participants retrieved their order from a locker or received their package from a store associate.

Post-Task Interview

After completing the pickup process, participants participated in a short semi-structured interview lasting approximately 10–15 minutes.

During this conversation, researchers asked participants about

Introduction to the session (2 minutes)

- Explain the study purpose
- Confirm participant meets screening criteria
- Request verbal consent

Interview (10-15 minutes)

Discuss the participant's experience of the process from placing the order to their current pickup state.

Brief background questions (2-3 minutes)

- Moments when they felt confused or uncertain during pickup
- Whether the pickup process matched their expectations
- How they interpreted communication about pickup readiness or location
- Strategies they used to recover from missing information or errors



These interviews helped researchers contextualize observed behaviors and better understand participants' perceptions of the overall pickup experience.

Data Collection and Analysis: App Testing and In-Person Pickup

Both qualitative observational data and interview data were collected during the study. Following the testing sessions, the research team synthesized observations and interview responses using affinity mapping to identify recurring patterns, usability issues, and pain points in the pickup process. These issues were then evaluated and prioritized based on factors such as severity, complexity, and the number of participants affected.

This analysis enabled the research team to identify key challenges and opportunities for improving clarity, efficiency, and customer confidence in the Home Depot in-store pickup experience.

6. DATA COLLECTION MAP

Research Question	Method (Study Phase)	Data Collected	Source/Instrument
RQ1: How effectively can DIY customers navigate the online ordering process for in-store pickup?	Moderated usability testing with think-aloud protocol (App Testing)	Task success rate, errors, time on task, navigation paths, participant comments during ordering tasks	Screen recordings, think-aloud notes, task observation templates
	Pre-test interview (App Testing)	Participant experience with DIY projects, Home Depot usage patterns, familiarity with online ordering and pickup services	Moderator interview script



	Post-test interview (App Testing)	Perceived clarity of pickup options, understanding of pickup timelines, and reflections on ordering experience	Semi-structured interview notes
	Post-test questionnaire (App Testing)	Perceived ease of use of the ordering flow	Likert scale responses
RQ2: How do customers' expectations about pickup timelines and processes align with what Home Depot communicates and the actual in-store experience?	Moderated usability testing observations (App Testing)	Moments of hesitation and confusion in interpreting pickup eligibility, fulfillment options, and readiness timing	Observational notes from think-aloud sessions
	Post-test interview (App Testing)	Customer expectations about when and how pickup should occur after placing an order	Interview notes
	Customer intercept interviews (In-Store Pickup Testing)	Customer reflections immediately after pickup, comparison between expected and actual pickup process	Brief semi-structured interview notes



RQ3: What factors enable or impede effective communication and interaction during the in-store pickup experience?	Fly-on-the-wall observation (In-Store Pickup Testing)	Store navigation patterns, interactions with pickup lockers or help desk, reactions to signage and pickup instructions	Field observation notes and photographs of touchpoints
	Behavioral observation during pickup tasks (In-Store Pickup Testing)	Moments of hesitation, workarounds, breakdown recovery behaviors during pickup	Structured observation templates
	Post-pickup interview (In-Store Pickup Testing)	Customer perceptions of pickup clarity, authentication steps, and overall pickup efficiency	Semi-structured interview responses

7. OVERALL FINDINGS

7.1 Successes

Index

Test area	Test Area shorthand + s (success)	Participant 1 shorthand	Code becomes
App Testing	As	P1	As.P1
In-Store Locker	Ls	P1	Ls.P1



In-Store Customer Service Desk Ds

P1

Ds.P1

Success 3 (As 1.1) - Map view for selecting preferred store is helpful

Participants (2/7) provided positive feedback for the map view when selecting their preferred store, as it allowed them to compare their current and store locations without needing to exit the app to determine their location.

"I like map view so I don't need to go to Google Maps to search the exact location." [A.P7]

Success 4 (As 2.1) - Variety of options for tailoring search

Participants (2/7) found the large variety of options present helpful for tailoring their search. Depending on their context (e.g., whether they had the product on hand to use the bar code scan or had a specific option they wanted to fulfill their purchase using), this provided them a shortcut to speed up their search process, potentially removing extra steps or clutter from less related content in between.

"I could have used the bar code to scan the item since I have access to it at home...and read the reviews." [A.P4]

"I also see chips...instore today, free 1-2 day delivery. I like this because it's like a more visible filter. Usually when I shop on Amazon, I also look for something I can get within 1-2 days, so this is useful. Pretty convenient." [A.P7]

Success 5 (As 2.2) - Visibility of specifications in product titles

2/7 participants appreciated the visibility of specifications in the product titles. For one, this provided an implicit reminder to double-check product specifications and ensure the product they purchased was correct for their project needs. For another, they had noticed this as an improvement in Home Depot's online interface, where previously this information was not immediately available and required additional steps to view.

"If I came more prepared and knew to search for this project, then I would search for shelves that size. But since I don't, it's helpful to have that reminder even if it's not helpful for what I'm trying to choose right now." [A.P1]

"Oh, the product dimensions are better organized now because they are clearly listed compared to the past." [A.P3]



Success 1 (Ls. P1) - Reduced wait time with locker pickup

One of the most notable successes of the locker pickup experience was its ability to significantly reduce wait time compared to the customer service desk. Participants consistently described the locker pickup as quick and straightforward (3/7 participants) and appreciated that they are right by the entrance and easy to see right away. The volume of products in store can make shopping in person feel overwhelming, so ordering online and picking up via locker allows them to get exactly what they need without having to navigate the store floor, making the whole buy online pickup in store process feel more efficient.

"Last time I had to wait 10-15 mins in the [desk] pickup line." [L.P1]

Success 2 (Ds 4.1) - Matches other retail experiences

Participants found the desk pickup process straightforward, comparing it to familiar experiences at Target, Walmart, and even fast food. Customer service at the pickup desk was a highlight, though floor support was noted as lacking. Proximity and convenience kept participants coming back over competitors like Lowe's.

"Fine. Same as anywhere else. Same as Walmart or fast food, it seems straightforward." [D.P1]

7.2 Issues

Index

Category + i (issue)	Task Number	Issue Number	Code becomes
App Testing Issue (Ai)	1	2	Ai1.2
In-Store General Issue (Gi)	1	2	Gi1.2
In-Store Locker Issue (Li)	1	2	Li1.2

**App Testing issues (Ai) span tasks 1-5, while Instore General Issues (Gi) and Instore Locker Issues (Li) span tasks 6-9.*



Scope	App Testing Scope	In-Store Testing Scope
Local	Page-specific issue	Store-specific issue
Global	Across pages issue	Across stores/system issue

Complexity	Severity
How difficult is the problem to fix? • Easy • Moderate • Difficult	Level 1 ▾ Subtle problem Level 2 ▾ Has a minor effect on usability Level 3 ▾ Significant delay and frustration Level 4 ▾ Prevents completion of a task

Task 1: Selecting your preferred store to shop from.

Issue 1:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Ai1.1	Need to see inventory available at specific store locations	Local	Easy	Level 2 ▾

Number of Participants: 3/7

Description: Participants' preferences for prioritizing inventory vs. store proximity differ, but the app primarily prompts users to first determine a store location to shop at. For users whose priorities differ from the app's prioritization, this leads to them expending additional effort broadening their search and manually checking product availability at multiple store locations, rather than having the options already narrowed as allowed in the app's prioritization. Participants also desire clearer visibility of inventory at each store to minimize the possibility of misselecting and needing to reselect items for purchase.



Evidence: Participant wanted clearer visibility into what is available at each specific store because they prefer buying from their closest location. [A.P5]

The “in stock at...” message beside the fulfillment option descriptions in the product listings is cut off, resulting in participants’ uncertainty regarding which location the product is available at. [A.P3]

Touchpoint: Store selection, product listings in search results, search results page filters.

Heuristics Violated: Visibility of system status, product inventory is not immediately visible. Flexibility and efficiency of use: the order in which search is narrowed in the app is fixed but could better support different users who prioritize a different order for narrowing search.

Recommendations: Allow users to set their search priority upfront rather than requiring store selection first, and ensure inventory status and store location are fully visible on product listing cards.

Issue 2:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Ai1.2	Difficulty identifying current/active stores	Global	Moderate	Level 3 ▾

Number of Participants: 2/7

Description: In the “My Store Selections” tab, the current store selection is uncertain, as the wording of “My Store” and “only results from [store]” is not clear, and participants may not immediately associate a store name with a given location. Some participants reselect their preferred store from the other store selection options (e.g., ZIP, current location) to make sure. Additionally, when selecting multiple stores, expectations for product inventory and fulfillment location options are not clear, resulting in some concern that if not paying close attention, the user may end up having to complete their pickup at a different location than anticipated.

Evidence: Participant was unclear which store was set as “My Store,” because the app doesn’t clearly show the active store, so they re-selected it.” [A.P2]

Touchpoint: “My Store Selections” tab, product fulfillment options in product listing/details/cart pages



Heuristics Violated: Match between system and real world – lack of clarity in wording regarding which store “My Store” corresponds to and what “only results from [store]” beneath “My Store” means, and whether selecting multiple stores will lead to inconsistent results in terms of product inventory and fulfillment location options.

Recommendations: Simplify or clarify the association between “My Store” and “Only results from [store],” as it is unclear what “only results” refers to. Make clear expectations for how product listings or fulfillment options will be organized/prioritized if multiple locations are selected, for example, an inline or expandable note when selecting multiple stores.

Issue 3:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Ai1.3	Coordinate pickups from multiple places	Global	Moderate	Level 1 ▾

Number of Participants: 2/7

Description: Participants find it challenging when they discover products in their cart are available at different store locations, as it indicates they may have to coordinate pickups from multiple places.

Evidence: *Participant finds it challenging when products in their cart are available at different store locations and they have to coordinate pickups from multiple places. [A.P2]*

Touchpoint: Cart page

Heuristics Violated: Flexibility and efficiency of use – lack of support for users to coordinate pickups for specific location(s)/time(s).

Recommendations: Develop a way to deselect items and purchase the item that could be picked up at the preferred store location. This will allow shoppers not to restart the buy online process. When communicating this conflict to users, include, if available, options to resolve it (e.g., scheduling and consolidating the order at a later date if products are expected to be available at a given location then).



Task 2: Search and select an item.

Issue 1:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Ai2.1	Cluttered & confusing information structure	Global	Moderate	Level 3 ▾

Number of Participants: 2/7

Description: Participants experienced difficulties with processing large amounts of information displayed on the app's interface and a feeling of "lost"-ness when navigating it because there is a lack of a clear understanding for how or why it is grouped and ordered the way it is.

Evidence: "I have the feeling they want to provide us too much information. The information is not well-grouped. It makes me feel lost when narrowing down my decisions." [A.P7]

"Just these ads could be removed to keep it more simple...I'd also like to see the product right there instead of choosing types of material." [A.P7]

Touchpoint: Search results page (when displaying categories, project guide text, and ads rather than individual vertical lists of product listings)

Heuristics Violated: Aesthetic and minimalist design – the app displays a large amount of content that is difficult to follow the organization and ordering of.

Recommendations: Provide users a high-level overview of different sections within the search result page (promoted products, category cards, project guides, etc.); allow users to choose their starting point when browsing different product options (e.g., between categories, project guides, vertical lists of individual products, etc.).

Issue 2:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Ai2.2	Search is hard to narrow without product specifications	Global	Difficult	Level 3 ▾



Number of Participants: 6/7

Description: Participants experienced difficulties narrowing their product selection when they did not have technically precise and complete visions of what they were looking for. In these cases participants relied on a lengthy process of inputting approximate searches and identifying the product name or specification by product images to narrow the search, then repeating several times until they either located their desired item, found one that they believed was of around the correct specifications, or gave up finding the desired item.

Evidence: *“As I'm looking through this I'm realizing there's lots of measurements involved. I don't know the exact measurements of my wall. There's a lot of options for shelves and measurements, and I'm not too sure what the difference is.” [A.P1]*

“Not everyone knows standard dimensions.” [A.P3]

The participant did not know the exact name for their desired product when doing a product search and had to rely on the product images to identify the likely name for their product. [A.P6]

Touchpoint: Search, search results page while browsing/filtering product listings

Heuristics Violated: Flexibility and efficiency of use – little guidance is provided to enable successful product search without product/project specifications immediately on hand.

Recommendations: Integrate contextual project-based guidance within search and filter (e.g., tooltips to explain standard measurements). This issue also compounds with and could be addressed together with Ai2.3 (product listings are not organized as users expect).

Issue 3:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Ai2.3	Product listings are not organized as users expect	Global	Difficult	Level 3 ▾

Number of Participants: 6/7

Description: Product listings across both search results and suggested products did not align with how participants expected they would be organized. Some pages displayed horizontally scrolling categories, ads, and project guidance, while some participants expected vertical lists



of individual products. For participants who did not enter the app with specific product attributes in mind, this led to increased search time due to having to repeatedly enter/exit preset categories or readapt their search strategies; in one case the participant gave up on finding their ideal product. Some participants also noted the way products were organized across Home Depot's store and app was inconsistent. This led to users having to restart the search process and remember specific attributes of related products, rather than being able to naturally locate the product where they had experienced it to be in another Home Depot platform.

Participants also experienced issues with the relevance of products in the search results. In response, 3 participants attempted several additional search queries in terms of syntax and precision, but to little avail in terms of yielding accurate search results or clarity on why search results remained inaccurate.

Evidence: *"I thought the items would be in 'Suggested.' In-store, the items would be located right next to one another."* [A.P4]

"I suspect product bias because the system repeatedly surfaces similar but incorrect items. See, search pushes PEX B even when I type PEX A." [A.P2]

Touchpoint: Frequently bought together section of product details page, search results page (when displaying categories, project guide text, and ads rather than individual vertical lists of product listings)

Heuristics Violated: Consistency and standards – search results are not consistently displayed (e.g., horizontal categories vs. vertical lists) across different search inputs; products in the frequently bought together section are not consistent with how users expect them to be based on their experience of how they are organized in-store. Match between system and real world – the system fails to understand the user's language and provide relevant information via search results.

Recommendations: To improve predictability and decision-making around search: Make transparent how **search ranking works**; standardize product organization across platforms; provide options for product listing views (e.g., category cards vs. list view of individual products).



Issue 4:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Ai2.4	The app is not optimized for multi-product comparison	Global	Difficult	Level 3 ▾

Number of Participants: 5/7

Description: Participants felt that the product view did not support multi-product comparison. In part this may have been facilitated by the constraints of the mobile (vs. wider web) screen width. For example, a wider website screen width allowed for participants to more easily switch through a variety of filters, as well as see more products and specifications at once. One participant also expressed that the horizontally scrolling categories in some search results pages hid products, which prevented them from being able to view and compare more products at once.

Evidence: *“The app feels frustrating for large projects because complex specifications are harder to manage on mobile.” (in terms of the ability to compare whether different product parts are compatible by switching desktop tabs) [A.P3]*

Touchpoint: Search results, product details pages

Heuristics Violated: Flexibility and efficiency of use – limited support for multi-product comparison/display.

Recommendations: Introduce comparison or shortlisting features within the app, for example, a dedicated side-by-side products comparison tab that is present through the search interface that users can easily expand or collapse as they are browsing products.

Issue 5:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Ai2.5	Difficulty distinguishing visually similar products	Global	Difficult	Level 3 ▾

Number of Participants: 3/7



Description: Participants sometimes experienced difficulties distinguishing between visually similar products due to a lack of a clear visual/label distinction or support for comparing specifications between multiple items. This issue can lead to incorrect purchases.

Evidence: *“PEX A and PEX B look identical in results because the thumbnails and titles look nearly identical...I’ve bought the wrong item before because the differences weren’t clear.”*
[A.P2]

Touchpoint: Search results page

Heuristics Violated: Recognition rather than recall – users need to consciously distinguish between products based on their knowledge of the product as they are browsing, rather than the distinction being immediately clear to the user.

Recommendations: Include clear visual and textual differentiators (e.g., bolding key differentiating information) to product listings at the search results level.

Task 3: Verify whether the product is eligible for buy online and pick up in store.

Issue 1:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Ai3.1	Inconsistent and confusing fulfillment terms	Global	Easy	Level 3 ▾

Number of Participants: 5/7

Description: Ship to Store & Pickup are distinct fulfillment services but are displayed in the same place (i.e., to the left of the Delivery option in the product details page). This can lead to incorrect fulfillment selections. Prior to entering the product details page, the fulfillment descriptions may also show pickup and ship to store directly next to each other, though in reality only one of the options is available, as indicated by whichever is bolded. However, this might not be immediately obvious to first-time customers who are not familiar with the terms used.



Evidence: “Ok, so it’s in stock...” – the participant says as they make a mistake and select “Ship to Store” for “Pickup” while adding their product to cart. [A.P3]

Touchpoint: Product details page, when selecting a fulfillment option prior to adding a product to cart; individual product listing fulfillment descriptions prior to entering the product details page.

Heuristics Violated: Consistency and standards – a different fulfillment option is in the same location of the page, leading to a potentially incorrect selection. Recognition rather than recall – users must learn the terms to understand the distinctions between different fulfillment options.

Recommendations: Standardize, clearly define, and visually distinguish fulfillment terminology across all screens.

Task 4: Place an order for this item, with the correct configurations for when you'd like to pick it up.

Issue 1:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Ai4.1	Forced account creation without guest checkout option	Global	Moderate	Level 3 ▾

Number of Participants: 3/7

Description: Participants did not appreciate having to create an account to complete their purchase if choosing not to use Apple Pay or PayPal, which they felt added more friction to an otherwise simple transaction. One participant specifically called out the need for a guest checkout option that would allow them to complete their order without logging in or creating an account.

Evidence: “Do I need to enter all my information?...Don’t love that I have to create an account to place an order.” [A.P5]



“This is the first time I’ve used this service and I’m not sure if I will be satisfied with this whole experience, so I don’t want to make an account right now.” [A.P7]

Touchpoint: Checkout, when prompted to enter an email address

Heuristics Violated: User control and freedom – participants do not have equivalent guest checkout options aside from specific payment options (PayPal, Apple Pay) and Checkout (which prompts the user for their email to create an account).

Recommendations: Make the expectation clear if login or account creation is required for standard checkout prior to users selecting the option, or give them the option to skip account creation when they are prompted to enter their email address.

Logging in or creating an account is REQUIRED, unless you bypass that by using Apple Pay/PayPal.

Issue 2:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Ai4.2	Payment and checkout issues 	Local	Moderate	Level 3 ▾

Number of Participants: 4/7

Description: Participants do not know what to expect for next steps pertaining to their order if they choose to not create or log into an account for order payment, leading to some hesitation and frustration regarding which option to choose.

Evidence: *The participant could not locate their order details from the app since they used Apple Pay. [A.P4]*

Touchpoint: Checkout, when prompted to enter an email address; alternative payment options in the Cart page.

Heuristics Violated: Help and documentation – while the checkout flow prompts the user for their contact information, implicitly indicating that they may receive further communication about their order from there, this is lacking in the alternative payment options.



Recommendations: Include a concise note (e.g., inline, or collapsible/expandable) of whether different checkout options will involve different expectations for pickup next steps beside the options for users to reference when making decisions about which to proceed with.

Issue 3:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Ai4.3	System status and loading issues causing uncertainty	Global	Difficult	Level 3 ▾

Number of Participants: 3/7

Description: Participants experienced issues repeating or correcting previous selections while managing their cart due to uncertainty of which tasks have/have not been processed, as well as loading issues that occurred in the process. One issue includes that only the loading icon is displayed while the system is loading, and there are no indicators that any actions have been processed then or if the user exits the loading tab. For standardizing the fulfillment options in the cart, the reminder that there are multiple items in the cart with potentially different fulfillment options does not consistently provide feedback to indicate the state of those items or if a change has been processed.

Evidence: *Participant checks the cart to confirm whether an item was added because slow loading creates doubt about system responsiveness. [A.P5]*

Touchpoint: Selecting Add to Cart for a product from the product details page or Cart page when standardizing fulfillment options for multiple items

Heuristics Violated: Visibility of system status – state changes are not clearly communicated when there are loading issues or when standardizing order fulfillment options for multiple items in the cart.

Recommendations: Communicate what is happening and why if the app is taking a while to load, and if necessary, what steps users might take when encountering this. The reminder banner in the cart for multiple items or fulfillment settings should consistently and visibly reflect any changes made in the cart.



Issue 4:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Ai4.4	Account difficulties 	Local	Difficult	Level 2 ▾

Number of Participants: 2/7

Description: Some participants who chose the standard checkout method ended up exiting the flow and opting for an alternative payment method (e.g., Apple Pay) because they were prompted to reset their password for a Home Depot account they could not remember. For participants who did not have an account and created one through this process, there was a lack of visibility and resulting uncertainty on their membership status.

Evidence: *Participant not sure if they've joined as a member at the time of checkout. [A.P5]*

**Prompted to enter new password* "Usually at this point, I would just go back and use Apple Pay." [A.P4]*

Touchpoint: Checkout, when prompted to enter an email address

Heuristics Violated: Visibility of system status – lack of a clear indication regarding participant account status after entering personal information pertaining to account creation during checkout. Flexibility and efficiency of use – lack of options between standard checkout (requiring account login) versus specific, limited payment options (Apple Pay, PayPal).

Recommendations: Make clear any changes to users' membership status when creating an account via the standard checkout process, e.g., a confirmation message noting their new status.

Task 5: Confirm the order has been placed, and that the items are all correct

Issue 1:



Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Ai5.1	Pickup location is not clear prior to pickup	Global	Easy	Level 2 ▾

Number of Participants: 2/7

Description: A couple of participants both felt that pickup instructions were unclear prior to pickup and were not motivated to examine the entirety of order email content to find the pickup instructions due to the large amount of content in the emails.

Evidence: *"I rely on the email having a QR code or not to determine the pickup spot because the app doesn't clearly explain pickup steps post-purchase."* [A.P2]

Touchpoint: Order emails

Heuristics Violated: Aesthetic and minimalist design – there is a large amount of content in emails that participants must sift through to locate pickup steps.

Recommendations: Condense/remove non-pickup related, redundant content within and across email communications (e.g., the locker code is mentioned twice in the locker pickup notification, as is the estimated pickup date in the order confirmation email). Include clear expectations for what subsequent pickup steps and email communications will entail in the initial order confirmation as well as the pickup readiness notification.

Task 6: Pickup instruction comprehension & understanding where to go

Issue 1:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Gi6.1	Unclear communication about pickup location	Global	Easy	Level 1 ▾

Number of Participants: 3/5

Description: Participants often struggled to determine whether their order should be picked up at lockers or the customer service desk. The instructions provided in emails and notifications



were not immediately clear, which led some participants to default to their previous experiences or assumptions rather than following system instructions.

Evidence: *"I don't think it was obvious. The previous order was in a locker... so I came back to the desk." [D.P3]*

Touchpoint: Order ready email notification, order confirmation/order status page

Heuristics Violated: Visibility of system status – The system fails to clearly inform users where the order is located.

Recommendations: Clearly state the pickup location in the email header, app notification, and order confirmation screen. Use a visual label such as "Pickup Location: Locker" or "Pickup Location: Service Desk" along with store directions.

Issue 2:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Gi6.2	Pickup instructions are buried in emails or notifications	Local	Moderate	Level 2 ▾

Number of Participants: 2/5

Description: Participants frequently skim emails and notifications and therefore miss important pickup instructions. Critical information such as authentication requirements or pickup location details is often embedded within longer messages rather than clearly surfaced.

Evidence: *"I just saw that my order was ready." *Pulls out phone to check email.* [D.P4]*

The participant skims emails or relies only on notifications because pickup instructions are not immediately clear or prominent. [D.P3]

Touchpoint: Order ready email notification (should be push notifications / sms notifications)

Heuristics Violated: Recognition rather than recall - Users must search through emails to find critical pickup instructions instead of seeing them immediately.



Recommendations: Provide concise pickup instructions at the top of emails and notifications, highlighting key steps such as pickup location, authentication requirements, and order readiness status.

Issue 3:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Gi6.3	Unable to select pickup method explicitly (locker vs helpdesk)	Global	Difficult	Level 2 ▾

Number of Participants: 2/5

Description: Participants expected the system to allow them to explicitly choose their preferred pickup method (i.e., locker vs. desk pickup). When this information was unclear, participants relied on assumptions based on previous experiences with other platforms and directly went to the helpdesk.

Evidence: *"I thought you get to choose how you pickup. Amazon does say 'do you want to pickup at locker.'" [L.P5]*

Touchpoint: Checkout/fulfillment selection screen, order confirmation screen

Heuristics Violated: User control and freedom – Users expect to choose their pickup method but are not given clear control.

Recommendations: Introduce a clear pickup method during checkout, confirming whether the order will be retrieved from lockers or the service desk.

Issue 4:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Gi6.4	Pickup date and time expectations are unclear	Global	Moderate	Level 4 ▾

Number of Participants: 3/5



Description: Participants experienced confusion regarding when items would be ready for pickup and how long they would remain available. Lack of clarity around readiness timelines sometimes caused unnecessary trips or uncertainty about pickup deadlines.

Evidence: *"Give me a deadline to pick up all items."* [D.P3]

"I wish it was more obvious that not all items were ready at the same time." [D.P3]

Touchpoint: Product availability & checkout page, order status / order ready notification

Heuristics Violated: Visibility of system status – The system does not clearly communicate order readiness timelines.

Recommendations: Display clear readiness timelines and pickup windows, including estimated pickup dates and expiration deadlines for orders after checkout.

Task 7: Locate the right pickup area once you reach the store

Issue 1:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Gi7.1	Pickup areas are difficult to locate in store	Local	Moderate	Level 3 ▾

Number of Participants: 3/5

Description: Some participants experienced difficulty locating pickup lockers or the service desk when arriving at the store. Without clear signage or directions, customers had to rely on memory or previous experience.

Evidence: *The participant defaults to the customer service desk for pickup because the email and notifications do not clearly state whether the order is in a locker or at the help desk.* [D.P3]

Touchpoint: Store entrance/wayfinding signage (should be pickup instruction email or app directions)



Heuristics Violated: Recognition rather than recall – Customers must remember where lockers or pickup areas are rather than being guided visually.

Recommendations: Improve in-store signage and wayfinding, including directional signs near entrances and digital confirmation screens that guide customers to the appropriate pickup location.

Issue 2:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Gi7.2	Customers default to habit instead of instructions	Global	Moderate	Level 3 ▾

Number of Participants: 3/5

Description: Some participants relied on their previous experiences when navigating the pickup process rather than reading updated instructions. This caused confusion when the system or pickup method had changed.

Evidence: *The participant always goes directly to the help desk for pickup because that has been their habit for years. [D.P4]*

Touchpoint: Order ready email notification, in-store pickup signage

Heuristics Violated: Recognition rather than recall – The system does not reinforce new instructions clearly enough for users to notice changes.

Recommendations: Reinforce pickup instructions through multiple touchpoints, including email confirmations, push notifications, and store signage, especially when something new is introduced, like the locker pickup.

Task 8: Authenticate Your Pickup

Issue 1:



Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Li8.1	QR Code scanning is not always easy or reliable	Global	Difficult	Level 3 ▾

Number of Participants: 2/5

Description: Participants experienced difficulty aligning their phone screen with the QR scanner, which slowed down the authentication process.

Evidence: *“The difficult feature would be the QR code having to fit into the small box screen; you have to ‘learn’ to move it to fill the QR code box.” [L.P2]*

Touchpoint: Locker qr scanner interface, pickup confirmation email

Heuristics Violated: Error prevention – Small scan areas and alignment issues increase the likelihood of scanning errors.

Flexibility and efficiency of use – The process is not optimized for quick interactions.

Recommendations: Improve scanner tolerance and visual guidance by enlarging scan areas and providing clearer alignment indicators.

Issue 2:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Gi8.2	Authentication requirements are not always clear	Global	Moderate	Level 3 ▾

Number of Participants: 2/5

Description: Participants were sometimes unsure what form of authentication was required when picking up an order, such as ID, QR code, or confirmation email.

Evidence: *“I don't think they make it difficult. You just have to carry your ID.” [D.P4]*

Participant struggled to find their ID. [D.P2]



Touchpoint: Order ready email notification, pickup desk interaction

Heuristics Violated: Visibility of system status – Users are not clearly informed what credentials they must bring.

Recommendations: Provide clear authentication instructions in pickup notifications, including what documents or codes customers must bring.

Task 9: Complete the pickup

Issue 1:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Gi9.1	Order readiness can feel slower than expected	Global	Difficult	Level 3 ▾

Number of Participants: 2/5

Description: Participants expected faster pickup times, especially those who rely on quick access to materials for work or projects.

Evidence: *Participant wishes orders were always ready within 2–3 hours. Getting notified in one hour would be best as a contractor. [D.P1]*

Touchpoint: Order ready notification system

Heuristics Violated: Flexibility and efficiency of use – The pickup workflow does not support quick completion for frequent users.

Recommendations: Improve inventory synchronization and notification timing to ensure orders are ready when customers arrive.



Issue 2:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Gi9.2	Orders may require multiple pickup trips	Global	Moderate	Level 3 ▾

Number of Participants: 2/5

Description: Participants sometimes had to return to the store multiple times because different items in the same order became available at different times, and they weren't informed of it while ordering.

Evidence: *"I wish it was more obvious that not all items were ready at the same time."* [D.P3]

"I had no idea this was a special item. Making a second trip is not convenient." [D.P3]

Touchpoint: Order status / order ready notification, checkout fulfillment information

Heuristics Violated: Consistency and standards - Users expect one order to be ready at the same time, like other platforms allow one to do.

Recommendations: Clearly communicate partial vs. full order readiness, and provide options for consolidated pickup notifications.

Issue 3:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Gi9.3	Online ordering is increasing due to reduced in-store inventory	Global	Difficult	Level 2 ▾

Number of Participants: 2/5

Description: Participants reported increasingly relying on Buy Online Pickup In Store (BOPIS) because many products are no longer available in physical stores.

Evidence: *"They don't carry what I needed in store, but they have it online."* [D.P4]



"I just noticed over the years I have to do more of this buy online." [D.P4]

Touchpoint: Product availability display (App)

Heuristics Violated: Match between system and real world – The retail experience no longer aligns with users' expectations of in-store availability.

Recommendations: Ensure pickup workflows are optimized and frictionless, as this method is becoming more common.

Issue 4:

Code	Issue	Scope	Complexity	Severity
Gi9.4	Delivery and fulfillment options are inconsistent	Global	Difficult	Level 2 ▾

Number of Participants: 1/5

Description: Participants experienced confusion when products that were previously eligible for delivery became pickup-only items.

Evidence: *"The only major issue identified was inconsistent delivery eligibility because an item that used to ship home was suddenly pickup only." [D.P1]*

Touchpoint: Product availability page

Heuristics Violated: Consistency and standards – Delivery eligibility changes unexpectedly.

Recommendations: Provide clear messaging about fulfillment changes, particularly when delivery eligibility changes.

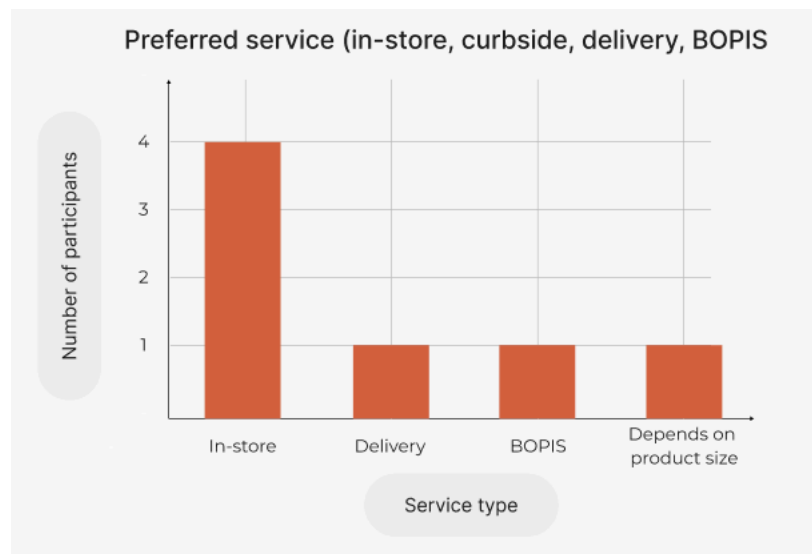
7.3 General Findings From App Testing

Method Preferences

Generally, participants preferred in-store shopping to evaluate the product for purchase confidence. They use BOPIS selectively when speed, convenience, or certainty about their desired product exists, rather than as a default shopping method. Likewise, online shopping

tends to be situational, used when information is needed quickly or when planning an in-store purchase.

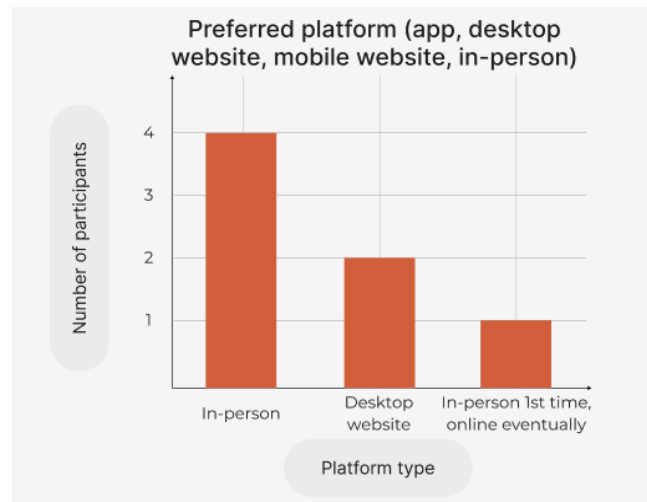
"I need to see precisely how it actually fits my needs. I probably wouldn't order online...but I might go online first to see that the specifications are matching before I go to the store." [A.P6]



App vs. Desktop Experience

In terms of platform preference, 4/7 participants generally preferred in-store shopping. The app was often seen as unnecessary for one-time or research-heavy purchases unless it could offer the same information visibility and ease of navigation of desktop shopping, which it currently lacks. Participants also expressed that for them, mobile works best for lightweight tasks, while desktop remains the preferred platform for deeper product research.

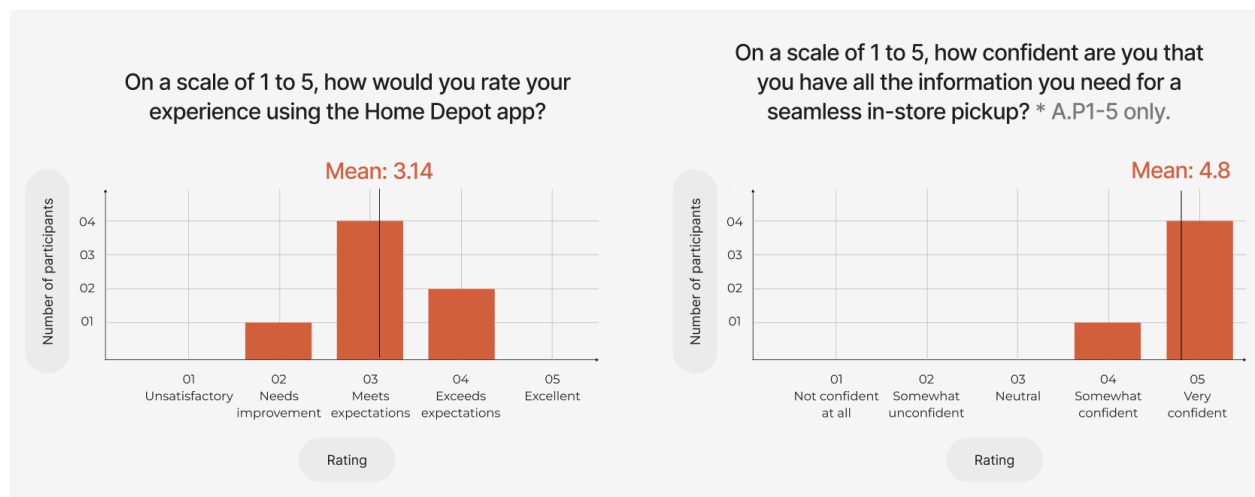
"I still prefer the in-person experience, especially for furniture. They're big items that I need to know precisely how it actually fits my needs. So I probably wouldn't order those online." [A.P1]



Post-test Likert Scale Questions

In general, participants' experience using the Home Depot app met expectations. Aside from the issues and successes noted, they stated that the general flow of search, filter, and checkout, and the features available met their expectations of a "standard" buy online for pickup experience.

Participants (out of the 7 tested, we only included this question later for participants 1-5) were also very confident that they had all the information necessary for a seamless in-store pickup, with only minor notes about being unsure when they will receive the ready-to-pickup notification.

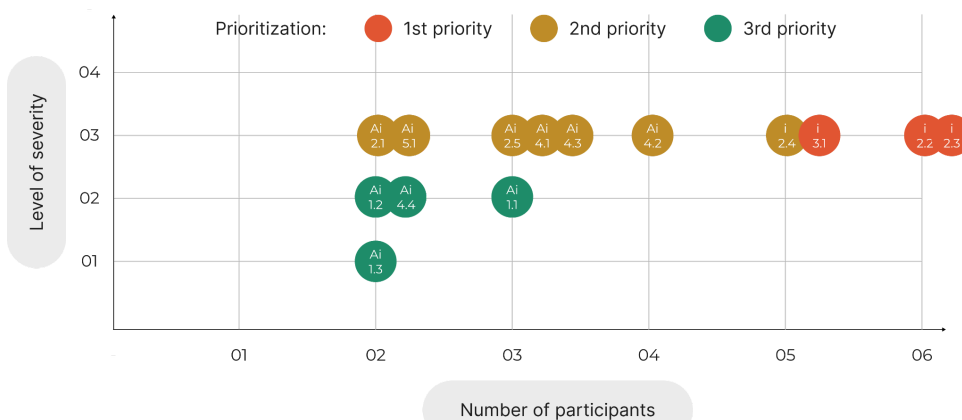


8. ANALYSIS

To analyze the usability issues identified during the study, each issue was assigned a **coded identifier (e.g., Gi 5.1, Gi 6.1)** that corresponds to the task stage and issue description documented in the findings table. These codes allow each issue in the prioritization chart to be directly traced back to the detailed issue descriptions, supporting observations, and participant quotes gathered during testing. The coded issues were then plotted on a prioritization chart using two dimensions: **severity level** and **number of participants affected**. Severity ratings followed the study's predefined scale, where **Level 1 represents subtle usability concerns, Level 2 minor usability impact, Level 3 significant delay or frustration, and Level 4 issues that prevent successful task completion**.

By utilizing affinity mapping, the issues were mapped across dimensions, and the research team was able to identify which usability problems had the greatest overall impact on the pickup experience. Issues that affected more participants and were rated with higher severity appear toward the **upper-right region of the chart** and were categorized as **first-priority issues**, representing the most critical usability breakdowns in the pickup workflow. Issues with moderate severity or affecting fewer participants were categorized as **second-priority findings**, while lower-severity issues with limited occurrence were categorized as **third-priority opportunities for improvement**. This prioritization approach helped the team focus recommendations on the issues most likely to improve the clarity, efficiency, and reliability of the Buy Online, Pick Up In Store experience.

Mapping the issues reported on number of participants, severity, complexity



Pictured Above: Prioritized Issues for App Testing



Pictured Above: Prioritized Issues for In-Store Testing

9. CONCLUSIONS

This study explored the usability of Home Depot’s Buy Online, Pick Up In Store (BOPIS) experience across multiple touchpoints, including the mobile app, order communication, and in-store pickup interactions. By examining the full omnichannel journey, our findings highlighted several usability challenges that affect how customers search for products, interpret fulfillment options, and navigate the in-store pickup process.

Across the experience, participants encountered friction in three key areas: product discovery, fulfillment clarity, and pickup communication. During app testing, participants often struggled to locate and compare products when they did not have precise specifications in mind, indicating the current search and product organization structure may not adequately support exploratory shopping behaviors. Additionally, fulfillment terminology such as “Pick Up” vs “Ship to Store” was oftentimes unclear, leading to uncertainty when selecting fulfillment options. Finally, communication surrounding pickup instructions and order readiness was not always immediately visible or easily understood by customers, which contributed to confusion about where to go and what to expect when arriving at the store.

Despite these challenges, this study also demonstrated that the BOPIS service provides clear value for customers who want to efficiently obtain items needed for home projects and/or everyday purchases. Participants expressed appreciation for the convenience of ordering online and retrieving items in-store, particularly when in a rush. These insights reinforce the



importance of the digital and physical components of BOPIS aligning to seamlessly execute the omnichannel shopping experience.

What Worked Well

We had an ambitious goal of using mixed methods across three phases of the omnichannel experience and successfully recruited participants and conducted studies for each phase. Managing recruitment successfully, scheduling participants and studies, note taking, and analyzing the data all within our allocated resources was a big undertaking, but it allowed us to create a more comprehensive understanding of the BOPIS experience than a single-method approach would have provided.

Reflections and Areas of Improvement

In hindsight, we would have liked to include a specific in-store interview question about whether participants clearly understood the pickup timeline, which would have allowed us to answer our research question more directly rather than inferring from the data we collected. We also would have benefited from conducting a more thorough review of secondary data prior to testing, including industry insights, app analytics, and previous BOPIS studies, to provide broader context for our findings.

In-store recruitment logistics also presented a few challenges. Through experience, we learned more about the customer traffic patterns at the locker and service desk areas; earlier coordination and understanding of this could have helped to optimize observation scheduling and timing. For example, scheduling in-store sessions during high-traffic periods such as weekends may have allowed the team to capture a broader range of pickup behaviors. That notwithstanding, our client sponsors' and research team's flexibility allowed us to capture data to support our research given our timeline constraints.

Recommendations for Future Research

For app testing, we created an easy to follow test script and note-taking spreadsheet that kept sessions organized. However, parts of the in-store templates we originally created were sometimes difficult to use in-store due to the fast-paced nature of real-time testing, and a more simplified note-taking sheet designed for clipboard use would have been better suited for the in-store environment.

Moving forward, we would incorporate full purchase and payment testing by offering mock payment options or small incentives to allow participants to complete purchases, as well as conduct a complete end-to-end BOPIS experience covering the full journey from browsing and



ordering online through to in-store pickup. After conducting our in-the-wild testing, simplifying portions of our documentation and using more conversational language would make the toolkit more practical and adaptable for field research.

Finally, future studies could benefit from focusing on specific user demographics identified during this research. For example, investigating the experiences of first-time Home Depot app users or DIY homeowners completing complex multi-product projects may reveal additional usability needs and findings that could be unique to those groups.

10. APPENDIX

10.1 [Screener Survey Link](#)

10.2 [Consent Form Link](#)

10.3 [Template for App Testing : Usability Testing](#)

10.4 [Template for In-Store Pick Up : Usability Testing](#)

10.5 [Analysis Affinity Map](#)